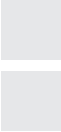




“The Uses of Sidewalks: Safety”

from *The Death and Life of
Great American Cities* (1961)



Jane Jacobs

EDITORS' INTRODUCTION



Jane Jacobs (1916–2006) started writing about city life and urban planning as a neighborhood activist and as associate editor of *Architectural Forum*, not as a trained planning professional. Dismissed as the original “little old lady in tennis shoes” and derided as a political amateur more concerned about personal safety issues than state-of-the-art planning techniques, she nonetheless struck a responsive chord with a 1960s public eager to believe the worst about arrogant city planning technocrats and just as eager to rally behind movements for neighborhood control and community resistance to “bulldozer redevelopment.”

The Death and Life of Great American Cities hit the world of city planning like an earthquake when it appeared in 1961. The book was a frontal attack on the planning establishment, especially on the massive urban renewal projects that were being carried out by powerful redevelopment bureaucrats like Robert Moses in New York. Jacobs derided urban renewal as a process that only served to create instant slums. She questioned universally accepted articles of faith – for example, that parks were good and that crowding was bad. Indeed she suggested that parks were often dangerous and that crowded neighborhood sidewalks were the safest places for children to play. Jacobs ridiculed the planning establishment's most revered historical traditions as “the Radiant Garden City Beautiful” – an artful phrase that not only airily dismissed the contributions of Le Corbusier (p. 379), Ebenezer Howard (p. 371), and Daniel Burnham but lumped them together as well! Lewis Mumford's “Home Remedies for Urban Cancer” (1962) – reprinted in both Elizabeth McDonald and Michael Larice (eds.), *The Urban Design Reader* (New York and London: Routledge: 2006) and Eugenie Birch's *The Urban and Regional Planning Reader* (New York and London: Routledge: 2008) – praises Jacobs's humanity and obvious love of city life but savages her attack on city planners like Ebenezer Howard and Patrick Geddes that Mumford had championed for decades.

The selection from *The Death and Life of Great American Cities* reprinted here presents Jane Jacobs at her very best. In “The Uses of Sidewalks: Safety,” she outlines her basic notions of what makes a neighborhood a community and what makes a city livable. Safety – particularly for women and children – comes from “eyes on the street,” the kind of involved neighborhood surveillance of public space that modern planning practice in the Corbusian tradition had destroyed with its insistence on superblocks and skyscraper developments. A sense of personal belonging and social cohesiveness comes from well-defined neighborhoods and narrow, crowded, multi-use streets. And, finally, basic urban vitality comes from residents' participation in an intricate “street ballet,” a diurnal pattern of observable and comprehensible human activity that is possible only in places like Jacobs's own Hudson Street in her beloved Greenwich Village.

It was this last quality, her unabashed love of cities and urban life, that is Jane Jacobs's most obvious and enduring characteristic. *The Death and Life of Great American Cities* was a scathing attack on the planning establishment – and, in many ways, it was a grassroots political call to arms – but it was also a loving invitation to experience the joys of city living that led many young, college-educated people to seek out neighborhoods like Greenwich Village as places to live, struggle, and raise families. In one sense the book encouraged and

justified middle-class gentrification of formerly working-class neighborhoods. In another, it found itself oddly reflected in the fantasy-nostalgia of “Sesame Street.” But in all ways it was committedly urban, never suburban, at a time when inner-city communities were being increasingly abandoned to the forces of poverty, decay, and neglect.

Contrast Louis Wirth’s theory of how population size, density, and heterogeneity in cities create a distinct urban personality (p. 115) with Jacobs’s argument that these very same city characteristics may create neighborhood vitality, social cohesion, and the perception and reality of safety. Jacobs’s notion of the “street ballet” invites comparison with Lewis Mumford’s idea of the “urban drama” (p. 110), William Whyte’s emphasis on the importance of public plazas (p. 587), Robert Putnam’s emphasis on “social capital” (p. 154), and Richard Florida’s vision of the urban community as a place for members of the “creative class” (p. 163). Jacobs’s community activism in resistance to urban renewal places her within a long tradition that includes Paul Davidoff’s “Advocacy and Pluralism in Planning” (p. 481) and Sherry Arnstein’s “A Ladder of Citizen Participation” (p. 279).

Other important works by Jane Jacobs include *The Economy of Cities* (New York: Random House, 1969) and *Systems of Survival* (New York: Random House, 1992). In the former book, Jacobs again turns conventional explanation on its head by arguing that the rise of cities may have proceeded, and even accounted for, rural agricultural development. The latter is a Platonic dialogue on “the moral foundations of commerce and politics.” More recently, she published *Dark Age Ahead* (New York: Random House, 2004), a study of contemporary cultural decay and a call for renewal of the key institutions of civilization: family, community, education, science, and the learned professions.

Max Allen, *Ideas that Matter: The Worlds of Jane Jacobs* (Ontario: Ginger Press, 1997) and Anthony Flint, *Wrestling with Moses: How Jane Jacobs Took On New York’s Master Builder and Transformed the American City* (New York: Random House, 2009) are of interest, and Robert A. Caro’s masterful study of Jacobs’s archenemy, *The Power Broker: Robert Moses and the Fall of New York* (New York: Random House, 1975), is essential.



Streets in cities serve many purposes besides carrying vehicles, and city sidewalks – the pedestrian parts of the streets – serve many purposes besides carrying pedestrians. These uses are bound up with circulation but are not identical with it and in their own right they are at least as basic as circulation to the proper workings of cities.

A city sidewalk by itself is nothing. It is an abstraction. It means something only in conjunction with the buildings and other uses that border it, or border other sidewalks very near it. The same might be said of streets, in the sense that they serve other purposes besides carrying wheeled traffic in their middles. Streets and their sidewalks, the main public places of a city, are its most vital organs. Think of a city and what comes to mind? Its streets. If a city’s streets look interesting, the city looks interesting; if they look dull, the city looks dull.

More than that, and here we get down to the first problem, if a city’s streets are safe from barbarism and fear, the city is thereby tolerably safe from barbarism and fear. When people say that a city, or a part of it, is

dangerous or is a jungle what they mean primarily is that they do not feel safe on the sidewalks. But sidewalks and those who use them are not passive beneficiaries of safety or helpless victims of danger. Sidewalks, their bordering uses, and their users, are active participants in the drama of civilization versus barbarism in cities. To keep the city safe is a fundamental task of a city’s streets and its sidewalks.

This task is totally unlike any service that sidewalks and streets in little towns or true suburbs are called upon to do. Great cities are not like towns, only larger. They are not like suburbs, only denser. They differ from towns and suburbs in basic ways, and one of these is that cities are, by definition, full of strangers. To any one person, strangers are far more common in big cities than acquaintances. More common not just in places of public assembly, but more common at a man’s own doorstep. Even residents who live near each other are strangers, and must be, because of the sheer number of people in small geographical compass.

The bedrock attribute of a successful city district is that a person must feel personally safe and secure on

the street among all these strangers. He must not feel automatically menaced by them. A city district that fails in this respect also does badly in other ways and lays up for itself, and for its city at large, mountain on mountain of trouble.

Today barbarism has taken over many city streets, or people fear it has, which comes to much the same thing in the end. "I live in a lovely, quiet residential area," says a friend of mine who is hunting another place to live. "The only disturbing sound at night is the occasional scream of someone being mugged." It does not take many incidents of violence on a city street, or in a city district, to make people fear the streets . . . And as they fear them, they use them less, which makes the streets still more unsafe.

To be sure, there are people with hobgoblins in their heads, and such people will never feel safe no matter what the objective circumstances are. But this is a different matter from the fear that besets normally prudent, tolerant and cheerful people who show nothing more than common sense in refusing to venture after dark – or in a few places, by day – into streets where they may well be assaulted, unseen or unrescued until too late. The barbarism and the real, not imagined, insecurity that gives rise to such fears cannot be tagged a problem of the slums. The problem is most serious, in fact, in genteel-looking "quiet residential areas" like that my friend was leaving.

It cannot be tagged as a problem of older parts of cities. The problem reaches its most baffling dimensions in some examples of rebuilt parts of cities, including supposedly the best examples of rebuilding, such as middle-income projects. The police precinct captain of a nationally admired project of this kind (admired by planners and lenders) has recently admonished residents not only about hanging around outdoors after dark but has urged them never to answer their doors without knowing the caller. Life here has much in common with life for the three little pigs or the seven little kids of the nursery thrillers. The problem of sidewalk and doorstep insecurity is as serious in cities which have made conscientious efforts at rebuilding as it is in those cities that have lagged. Nor is it illuminating to tag minority groups, or the poor, or the outcast with responsibility for city danger. There are immense variations in the degree of civilization and safety found among such groups and among the city areas where they live. Some of the safest sidewalks in New York City, for example, at any time of day or night, are those along which poor

people or minority groups live. And some of the most dangerous are in streets occupied by the same kinds of people. All this can also be said of other cities.

[. . .]

The first thing to understand is that the public peace – the sidewalk and street peace – of cities is not kept primarily by the police, necessary as police are. It is kept primarily by an intricate, almost unconscious, network of voluntary controls and standards among the people themselves, and enforced by the people themselves. In some city areas – older public housing projects and streets with very high population turnover are often conspicuous examples – the keeping of public sidewalk law and order is left almost entirely to the police and special guards. Such places are jungles. No amount of police can enforce civilization where the normal, casual enforcement of it has broken down.

The second thing to understand is that the problem of insecurity cannot be solved by spreading people out more thinly, trading the characteristics of cities for the characteristics of suburbs. If this could solve danger on the city streets, then Los Angeles should be a safe city because superficially Los Angeles is almost all suburban. It has virtually no districts compact enough to qualify as dense city areas. Yet Los Angeles cannot, any more than any other great city, evade the truth that, being a city, it is composed of strangers not all of whom are nice. Los Angeles' crime figures are flabbergasting. Among the seventeen standard metropolitan areas with populations over a million, Los Angeles stands so pre-eminent in crime that it is in a category by itself. And this is markedly true of crimes associated with personal attack, the crimes that make people fear the streets.

[. . .]

This is something everyone already knows: A well-used city street is apt to be a safe street. A deserted city street is apt to be unsafe. But how does this work, really? And what makes a city street well used or shunned? . . . What about streets that are busy part of the time and then empty abruptly?

A city street equipped to handle strangers, and to make a safety asset, in itself, out of the presence of strangers, as the streets of successful city neighborhoods always do, must have three main qualities:

First, there must be a clear demarcation between what is public space and what is private space. Public and private spaces cannot ooze into each other as they do typically in suburban settings or in projects.

Second, there must be eyes upon the street, eyes belonging to those we might call the natural proprietors of the street. The buildings on a street equipped to handle strangers and to insure the safety of both residents and strangers must be oriented to the street. They cannot turn their backs or blank sides on it and leave it blind.

And third, the sidewalk must have users on it fairly continuously, both to add to the number of effective eyes on the street and to induce the people in buildings along the street to watch the sidewalks in sufficient numbers. Nobody enjoys sitting on a stoop or looking out a window at an empty street. Almost nobody does such a thing. Large numbers of people entertain themselves, off and on, by watching street activity.

In settlements that are smaller and simpler than big cities, controls on acceptable public behavior, if not on crime, seem to operate with greater or lesser success through a web of reputation, gossip, approval, disapproval and sanctions, all of which are powerful if people know each other and word travels. But a city's streets, which must control the behavior not only of the people of the city but also of visitors from suburbs and towns who want to have a big time away from the gossip and sanctions at home, have to operate by more direct, straightforward methods. It is a wonder cities have solved such an inherently difficult problem at all. And yet in many streets they do it magnificently.

It is futile to try to evade the issue of unsafe city streets by attempting to make some other features of a locality, say interior courtyards, or sheltered play spaces, safe instead. By definition again, the streets of a city must do most of the job of handling strangers, for this is where strangers come and go. The streets must not only defend the city against predatory strangers, they must protect the many, many peaceable and well-meaning strangers who use them, insuring their safety too as they pass through. Moreover, no normal person can spend his life in some artificial haven, and this includes children. Everyone must use the streets.

On the surface, we seem to have here some simple aims: to try to secure streets where the public space is unequivocally public, physically unmixed with private or with nothing-at-all space, so that the area needing surveillance has clear and practicable limits; and to see that these public street spaces have eyes on them as continuously as possible.

But it is not so simple to achieve these objects, especially the latter. You can't make people use streets they have no reason to use. You can't make people

watch streets they do not want to watch. Safety on the streets by surveillance and mutual policing of one another sounds grim, but in real life it is not grim. The safety of the street works best, most casually, and with least frequent taint of hostility or suspicion precisely where people are using and most enjoying the city streets voluntarily and are least conscious, normally, that they are policing.

The basic requisite for such surveillance is a substantial quantity of stores and other public places sprinkled along the sidewalks of a district; enterprises and public places that are used by evening and night must be among them especially. Stores, bars and restaurants, as the chief examples, work in several different and complex ways to abet sidewalk safety.

First, they give people – both residents and strangers – concrete reasons for using the sidewalks on which these enterprises face.

Second, they draw people along the sidewalks past places which have no attractions to public use in themselves but which become traveled and peopled as routes to somewhere else; this influence does not carry very far geographically, so enterprises must be frequent in a city district if they are to populate with walkers those other stretches of street that lack public places along the sidewalk. Moreover, there should be many different kinds of enterprises, to give people reasons for crisscrossing paths.

Third, storekeepers and other small businessmen are typically strong proponents of peace and order themselves; they hate broken windows and holdups; they hate having customers made nervous about safety. They are great street watchers and sidewalk guardians if present in sufficient numbers.

Fourth, the activity generated by people on errands, or people aiming for food or drink, is itself an attraction to still other people.

This last point, that the sight of people attracts still other people, is something that city planners and city architectural designers seem to find incomprehensible. They operate on the premise that city people seek the sight of emptiness, obvious order and quiet. Nothing could be less true. People's love of watching activity and other people is constantly evident in cities everywhere.

[...]

Under the seeming disorder of the old city, wherever the old city is working successfully, is a marvelous order for maintaining the safety of the streets and the freedom of the city. It is a complex

order. Its essence is intricacy of sidewalk use, bringing with it a constant succession of eyes. This order is all composed of movement and change, and although it is life, not art, we may fancifully call it the art form of the city and liken it to the dance – not to a simple-minded precision dance with everyone kicking up at the same time, twirling in unison and bowing off en masse, but to an intricate ballet in which the individual dancers and ensembles all have distinctive parts which miraculously reinforce each other and compose an orderly whole. The ballet of the good city sidewalk never repeats itself from place to place, and in any one place is always replete with new improvisations.

The stretch of Hudson Street where I live is each day the scene of an intricate sidewalk ballet. I make my own first entrance into it a little after eight when I put out the garbage can, surely a prosaic occupation, but I enjoy my part, my little clang, as the droves of junior high school students walk by the center of the stage dropping candy wrappers. (How do they eat so much candy so early in the morning?)

While I sweep up the wrappers I watch the other rituals of morning: Mr. Halpert unlocking the laundry's handcart from its mooring to a cellar door, Joe Cornacchia's son-in-law stacking out the empty crates from the delicatessen, the barber bringing out his sidewalk folding chair, Mr. Goldstein arranging the coils of wire which proclaim the hardware store is open, the wife of the tenement's superintendent depositing her chunky 3-year-old with a toy mandolin on the stoop, the vantage point from which he is learning the English his mother cannot speak. Now the primary children, heading for St. Luke's, dribble through to the south; the children for St. Veronica's cross, heading to the west, and the children for P.S. 41, heading toward the east. Two new entrances are being made from the wings: well-dressed and even elegant women and men with briefcases emerge from doorways and side streets ... Most of these are heading for the bus and subways, but some hover on the curbs, stopping taxis which have miraculously appeared at the right moment, for the taxis are part of a wider morning ritual: having dropped passengers from midtown in the downtown financial district, they are now bringing downtowners up to midtown. Simultaneously, numbers of women in housedresses have emerged and as they crisscross with one another they pause for quick conversations that sound with either laughter or joint indignation; never, it seems, anything between. It is time for me to hurry to work

too, and I exchange my ritual farewell with Mr. Lofaro, the short, thick-bodied, white-aproned fruit man who stands outside his doorway a little up the street, his arms folded, his feet planted, looking solid as earth itself. We nod; we each glance quickly up and down the street then look back to each other and smile. We have done this many a morning for more than ten years, and we both know what it means: All is well.

[...]

I know the deep night ballet and its seasons best from waking: long after midnight to tend a baby and, sitting in the dark, seeing the shadows and hearing the sounds of the sidewalk. Mostly it is a sound like infinitely pattering snatches of party conversation and, about three in the morning, singing, very good singing. Sometimes there is sharpness and anger or sad, sad weeping, or a flurry of search for a string of beads broken. One night, a young man came roaring along, bellowing terrible language at two girls whom he had apparently picked up and who were disappointing him. Doors opened; a wary semicircle formed around him, not too close, until the police came. Out came the heads, too, along Hudson Street, offering opinion, "Drunk ... Crazy ... A wild kid from the suburbs." (He turned out to be a wild kid from the suburbs. Sometimes, on Hudson Street, we are tempted to believe the suburbs must be a difficult place to bring up children.)

I have made the daily ballet of Hudson Street sound more frenetic than it is, because writing it telescopes it. In real life, it is not that way. In real life, to be sure, something is always going on, the ballet is never at a halt, but the general effect is peaceful and the general tenor even leisurely. People who know well such animated city streets will know how it is. I am afraid people who do not will always have it a little wrong in their heads like the old prints of rhinoceroses made from travelers' descriptions of rhinoceroses. On Hudson Street, the same as in the North End of Boston or in any other animated neighborhoods of great cities, we are not innately more competent at keeping the sidewalks safe than are the people who try to live off the hostile truce of Turf in a blind-eyed city. We are the lucky possessors of a city order that makes it relatively simple to keep the peace because there are plenty of eyes on the street. But there is nothing simple about that order itself, or the bewildering number of components that go into it. Most of those components are specialized in one way or another. They unite in their joint effect upon the sidewalk, which is not specialized in the least. That is its strength.

The city reader

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“The Design of Spaces”

from *City: Rediscovering the Center* (1988)

William H. Whyte

EDITORS' INTRODUCTION



In 1969, puzzled by why some of New York's parks and plazas were well used while others were almost always nearly empty, the New York City Planning Commission asked sociologist William Whyte to study park and plaza use and help draft a comprehensive urban design plan to improve New York City's parks and plazas.

While he had no formal training in urban planning, landscape architecture, or design, Whyte's lucid writings in these areas gave him great credibility. Hunter College appointed him a distinguished professor, and the National Geographic Society gave him the first domestic expedition grant they had ever made to investigate what makes for good urban parks and plazas. Whyte named his study “The Street Life Project.”

Whyte worked with Hunter College students, bright young urban designers and planners at the New York City Planning Department, and other talented people he drew to the Street Life Project. This team produced an exceptional study of how people use urban space and a set of urban design guidelines for New York that have been widely praised and have had a profound positive impact on New York and many other cities. The Street Life Project morphed into the Project for Public Spaces, which has ably carried on Whyte's work in the United States and abroad as described in “What is Placemaking?” (p. 558) and “Placemaking and the Future of Cities” (p. 629).

The Street Life Project is an excellent example of qualitative urban research. Whyte formed hypotheses about how people use urban space. Then, he and his team observed how people used urban spaces (inductive reasoning). His team also spent a lot of time simply observing and then developing theory based on what they saw (deductive reasoning). Whyte tested his hypotheses by filming people using different plazas and parks in New York City and carefully analyzing the films, having his researchers note down who sat where during different times of the day and year, and personally watching people interact with each other and the physical spaces around them, looking always for clues about what people did and did not like about urban spaces.

Whyte's results were often surprising. Some initial hypotheses were validated, but Whyte had to reject or modify others, including many that seem intuitively obvious. Whyte hypothesized, for example, that the number of people using a plaza would be strongly influenced by the amount of space or its shape. More people should use big parks than little ones. But Chart 1 in [Figure 1](#) shows that is not the case. New Yorkers use tiny Greenacre Park much more than J.C. Penney Park, which is much larger. Intuitively more people should use a park that is about as wide as it is long than a long skinny park. But Whyte found that one of New York's most popular parks is just a long, narrow indentation in a building.

What does attract people to parks and plazas? Whyte eventually concluded that the amount of sittable space in a park or plaza was much more important than either the total space or its shape. The presence of food vendors, an open relationship to the street, water, movable chairs, sunlight (even reflected sunlight) and many other influences that were rarely included in formal park and plaza designs before Whyte's groundbreaking research turned out to make a big difference. Now they are routinely considered by urban designers influenced by Whyte's writings and the continuing work of the Project for Public Spaces. Whyte was one of the few male observers to carefully observe and write about how women used public spaces differently from men. Whyte

included women researchers in the Street Life Project and listened carefully to what they told him about how women used the spaces the team was observing. The Street Life Project was pioneering in its conscious observation of gender difference in how men and women use urban space. Whyte found that women are more discriminating than men as to where they will sit and are more sensitive to annoyances. He concluded that if a plaza has a high proportion of women, it is probably a good and well-managed one. Since this selection was written a wealth of important studies have looked at how men and women use urban public space differently and may have different needs, but Daphne Spain (p. 193) notes that most writing about the spatial organization of cities still either ignore gender differences or are written from a male perspective with, at best, a separate section on design implications for women. She calls for a “gender perspective” similar to the perspective Whyte and the Street Life Project incorporated into their research into all research and writings about cities and city planning.

William Whyte's ideas have had a wide impact. The New York City Planning Commission held hearings on his recommendations and, after much debate, adopted many of his suggestions as requirements or guidelines for new park and plaza development. Whyte helped develop a restoration plan for Bryant Park, and a public-private partnership inspired by Whyte's ideas tore down the iron fence isolating Bryant Park from the street, put in sitting space and food, and transformed a dangerous, little-used park into one bustling with life. On the other hand, the renovation of Bryant park pushed out homeless people, and the re-design arguably sent conscious and subconscious signals to many groups that they were not welcome in the ways that Ali Madanipour (p. 203) and Mike Davis (p. 212) describe. This highlights a fundamental issue in urban design – how to make designs inclusive and protect diverse groups’ “right to the city” as David Harvey describes (p. 270).

Good public spaces are the most important element in in Camillo Sitte's work on “the art of building cities” described in the introduction to this chapter and in H.D.F. Kitto's description of the bustling street life in the agora and other public spaces in the Greek polis (p. 39). Note the similarity between Whyte's description of Seagram's Plaza as the best of stages and Lewis Mumford's emphasis on the city as theater (p. 110). Whyte argues that most “undesirables” are harmless and comments that it takes real work to create a lousy place, but Mike Davis (p. 212) found that some designers in Los Angeles had worked hard (and successfully) to design public spaces to keep homeless people and other undesirables away. In contrast, the Project for Public Spaces urges urban designers to include neighborhood residents (the real experts) in planning and proposes many ways in which urban designers can make public spaces attractive (p. 558).

The way in which New York City encouraged parks and plazas is an interesting example how cities can use the economic incentives Wilbur Thompson (p. 305) suggests to encourage the type of development they want. Many New York parks and plazas are privately owned public open spaces (POPOs). There is a strong market for additional office space in the central business districts of many cities. Zoning ordinances set limits on the height and bulk of office buildings. Permission to build more office space than zoning ordinarily allows is worth money to developers. New York City awarded developers “density bonuses” allowing them to build more office space by building higher or bulkier buildings if the private developers agreed to provide park and plaza space at street level. New York analyzed the private market and granted enough additional square footage that almost all office developers participated in the program because it was in their economic self-interest to do so. Jonas Rabinovitch and Josef Leitman describe how Curitiba, Brazil, has used density bonuses modeled on the New York City example to good advantage (p. 504). While some developers worked hard to design attractive parks and plazas, other just wanted to build anything that would get them the density bonus. Some may have deliberately designed unattractive public spaces because they did not want the public near their private space. That helps explain the huge difference in the quality of urban parks and plazas in New York City and other cities with similar zoning laws and policies. Requiring the developers to meet design guidelines was intended to produce good parks and plazas.

William Hollingsworth “Holly” Whyte (1918–1999) was a sociologist and journalist who first achieved prominence with a 1956 study of corporate culture titled *The Organization Man* that sold more than two million copies. Whyte served as an advisor to Laurence S. Rockefeller on environmental issues and as a planning consultant for major US cities. He was a trustee of the American Conservation Association, and was active in the Municipal Art Society, the Hudson River Valley Commission, and President Lyndon B. Johnson's Task Force on Natural Beauty. But he remains best known for his work with the Street Life Project. The Project for Public Space,

a New York City organization, continues to promote Whyte's vision as described in the two PPS writings in this part of *The City Reader* (pp. 558, 629).

This selection is from *City: Rediscovering the Center* (New York: Anchor Books, 1988). In other chapters of *City*, Whyte explores water, wind, trees, light, steps and entrances, undesirables, walls, sun and shadows, and many other factors that affect public spaces. Whyte produced a delightful film titled *Public Spaces/Human Places* based on his research, which is available from Direct Cinema Limited in Los Angeles. The original report of Whyte's classic street life project – *The Social Life of Small Urban Spaces* (New York: Project for Public Spaces Inc., 2001) – is available from the Project for Public Spaces. Whyte's other writings include his bestselling *The Organization Man* (New York: Doubleday-Anchor, 1956) and *The Last Landscape* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2002). An anthology of William Whyte's most important writings is Albert LaFarge (ed.), *The Essential William Whyte* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2000).

Privately Owned Public Space: The New York City Experience by Harvard urban planning professor Jerold S. Kayden, the New York City Department of City Planning, and the Municipal Art Society of New York (New York: Wiley, 2000) describes New York City's experience with POPOs.

John M. Dixon is the author of five volumes of *Urban Spaces*: books with photographs of notable urban spaces: *Urban Spaces # 1* (New York: Watson-Guption Publications, 1999), *Urban Spaces # 2* (New York: Watson-Guption Publications, 1999), *Urban Spaces # 3* (New York: Visual Reference Publications 2004), *Urban Spaces # 4* (New York: Visual Reference Publications 2006), and *Urban Spaces # 5* (New York: Visual Reference Publications 2008).

Matthew Carmona's *Public Places: Urban Spaces*, 2nd edn (London and New York: Routledge) is an urban design textbook that focuses on public spaces. Oscar Newman's influential *Defensible Space* (New York: Macmillan, 1972) is a study of the way in which low-rent public housing project residents use space, with suggestions to architects and planners on how to meet their security concerns. Clare Cooper and Wendy Sarkissien's *Housing as if People Mattered* (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1986) provides practical suggestions for designing housing responsive to the needs of all residents, particularly working women and children. Allan Jacobs's *Looking at Cities* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1985) provides a stimulating discussion of how close observation like Whyte undertook can inform city planning, and how to do observational studies.



... Since 1961 New York City had been giving incentive bonuses to developers who would provide plazas ... Every new office building qualified for the bonus by providing a plaza or comparable space; in total, by 1972 some twenty acres of the world's most expensive open space.

Some plazas attracted lots of people ...

But on most plazas there were few people. In the middle of the lunch hour on a beautiful day the number of people sitting on plazas averaged four per thousand square feet of space – an extraordinarily low figure for so dense a center ...

... The city was being had. For the millions of dollars of extra floor space it was handing out to developers, it had every right to demand much better spaces in return.

I put the question to the chairman of the city planning commission, Donald Elliott ... He felt tougher zoning was in order. If we could find out why the good

places worked and the bad ones didn't and come up with tight guidelines, there could be a new code ...

We set to work. We began studying a cross section of spaces – in all, sixteen plazas, three small parks, and a number of odds and ends of space ...

[...]

We started by charting how people used plazas. We mounted time-lapse cameras at spots overlooking the plaza ... and recorded the dawn-to-dusk patterns. We made periodic circuits of the plazas and noted on sighting maps where people were sitting, their gender, and whether they were alone or with others ... We also interviewed people and found where they worked, how frequently they used the plaza, and what they thought of it. But mostly we watched what they did.

Most of them were young office workers from nearby buildings. Often there would be relatively few from the plaza's own building. As some secretaries confided, they would just as soon put a little distance

between themselves and the boss come lunchtime. In most cases the plaza users came from a building within a three-block radius. Small parks, such as Paley and Greenacre, had a somewhat more varied mix of people – with more upper-income older people – but even here office workers predominated.

This uncomplicated demography underscores an elemental point about good spaces: supply creates demand. A good new space builds a new constituency. It gets people into new habits – such as alfresco lunches – and induces them to use new paths . . .

The best-used plazas are sociable places, with a higher proportion of couples and groups than you will find in less-used places. At the plazas in New York, the proportion of people in twos or more runs about 50–62 percent; in the least-used, 25–30 percent. A high proportion is an index of selectivity. If people go to a place in a group or rendezvous there, it is most often because they decided to beforehand. Nor are these places less congenial to the individual. In absolute numbers, they attract more individuals than do the less-used spaces. If you are alone, a lively place can be the best place to be.

The best-used places also tend to have a higher than average proportion of women. The male–female ratio of a plaza reflects the composition of the work force and this varies from area to area. In midtown New York it runs about 60 percent male, 40 percent female. Women are more discriminating than men as to where they will sit, they are more sensitive to annoyances, and they spend more time casing a place. They are also more likely to dust off a ledge with their handkerchief.

The male–female ratio is one to watch. If a plaza has a markedly low proportion of women, something is wrong. Conversely, if it has a high proportion, the plaza is probably a good and well-managed one and has been chosen as such.

The rhythms of plaza life are much alike from place to place. In the morning hours, patronage will be sporadic . . .

Around noon the main clientele begins to arrive. Soon activity will be near peak and will stay there until a little before two . . .

Some 80 percent of the people activity on plazas comes during the lunchtime, and there is very little of any kind after five-thirty . . .

During the lunch period, people will distribute themselves over space with considerable consistency, with some sectors getting heavy use day in and day

out, others much less so. We also found that off-peak use often gives the best clues to people's preferences. When a place is jammed, people sit where they can; this may or may not be where they most want to. After the main crowd has left, however, the choices can be significant. Some parts of the plaza become empty; others continue to be used . . .

Men show a tendency to take the front row seats and if there is a kind of gate they will be the guardians of it. Women tend to favor places slightly secluded. If there are double-sided ledges parallel to the street, the inner side will usually have a higher proportion of women; the outer, of men.

Of the men up front the most conspicuous are the girl watchers. As I have noted, they put on such a show of girl watching as to indicate that their real interest is not so much the girls as the show. It is all machismo. Even in the Wall Street area, where girl watchers are especially demonstrative you will hardly ever see one attempt to pick up a girl.

Plazas are not ideal places for striking up acquaintances. Much better is a very crowded street with lots of eating and quaffing going on. An outstanding example is the central runway of the South Street Seaport. At lunch sometimes, one can hardly move for the crush. As in musical chairs, this can lead to interesting combinations. On most plazas, however, there isn't much mixing. If there are, say, two smashing blondes on a ledge, the men nearby will usually put on an elaborate show of disregard. Look closely, however, and you will see them giving away the pose with covert glances.

Lovers are to be found on plazas, but not where you would expect them. When we first started interviewing, people would tell us to be sure to see the lovers in the rear places. But they weren't usually there. They would be out front. The most fervent embracing we've recorded on film has taken place in the most visible of locations, with the couple oblivious of the crowd. (In a long clutch, however, I have noted that one of the lovers may sneak a glance at a wristwatch.)

Certain locations become rendezvous points for groups of various kinds. The south wall of the Chase Manhattan Plaza was, for a while, a gathering point for camera bugs, the kind who are always buying new lenses and talking about them. Patterns of this sort may last no more than a season – or persist for years. A black civic leader in Cincinnati told me that when he wants to make contact, casually, with someone, he usually knows just where to look at Fountain Square . . .

Standing patterns on the plazas are fairly regular. When people stop to talk they will generally do so athwart one of the main traffic flows, as they do on streets. They also show an inclination to station themselves near objects, such as a flagpole or a piece of sculpture. They like well-defined places, such as steps or the border of a pool. What they rarely choose is the middle of a large space.

There are a number of explanations. The preference might be ascribed to some primeval instinct: you have a full view of all comers but your rear is covered. But this doesn't explain the inclination men have for lining up at the curb. Typically, they face inward, with their backs exposed to the vehicle traffic of the street.

Whatever their cause, people's movements are one of the great spectacles of a plaza. You do not see this in architectural photographs, which are usually devoid of human beings and are taken from a perspective that few people share. It is a misleading one. Looking down on a bare plaza, one sees a display of geometry, done almost in monochrome. Down at eye level the scene comes alive with movement and color – people walking quickly, walking slowly, skipping up steps, weaving in and out on crossing patterns, accelerating and retarding to match the moves of others. Even if the paving and the walls are gray, there will be vivid splashes of color – in winter especially, thanks to women's fondness for red coats and colored umbrellas.

There is a beauty that is beguiling to watch, and one senses that the players are quite aware of this themselves. You can see this in the way they arrange themselves on ledges and steps. They often do so with a grace that they must appreciate themselves. With its brown-gray setting, Seagram is the best of stages – in the rain, too, when an umbrella or two puts spots of color in the right places, like Corot's red dots.

Let us turn to the factors that make for such places. The most basic one is so obvious it is often overlooked: people. To draw them, a space should tap a strong flow of them. This means location, and, as the old adage has it, location and location. The space should be in the heart of downtown, close to the 100 percent corner – preferably right on top of it.

Because land is cheaper further out, there is a temptation to pick sites away from the center. There may also be some land for the asking – some underused spaces, for example, left over from an ill-advised civic center campus of urban renewal days. They will be poor bargains. A space that is only a few

blocks too far might as well be ten blocks for all the people who will venture to walk to it.

People *ought* to walk to it, perhaps; the exercise would do them good. But they don't. Even within the core of downtown the effective radius of a good place is about three blocks. About 80 percent of the users will have come from a place within that area. This does indicate a laziness on the part of pedestrians and this may change a bit, just as the insistence on close-in parking may. But there is a good side to the constrained radius. Since usage is so highly localized, the addition of other good open spaces will not saturate demand. They will increase it.

Given a fine location, it is difficult to design a space that will not attract people. What is remarkable is how often this has been accomplished. Our initial study made it clear that while location is a prerequisite for success, it in no way assures it. Some of the worst plazas are in the best spots . . .

All of the plazas and small parks that we studied had good locations; most were on the major avenues, some on attractive side-streets. All were close to bus-stops or subway stations and had strong pedestrian flows on the sidewalks beside them. Yet when we rated them according to the number of people sitting at peak time, there was a wide range: from 160 people at 77 Water Street to 17 at 280 Park Avenue (Figure 1).

How come? The first factor we studied was the sun. We thought it might well be the critical one, and our first time-lapse studies seemed to bear this out. Subsequent studies did not. As I will note later they show that sun was important but did not explain the differences in popularity of plazas.

Nor did aesthetics . . . The elegance and purity of a complex's design, we had to conclude, had little relationship to the usage of the spaces around it.

[. . .]

Another factor we considered was the shape of spaces. Members of the commission's urban design group believed this was very important and hoped our findings would support tight criteria for proportions and placement. They were particularly anxious to rule out strip plazas: long, narrow spaces that were little more than enlarged sidewalks, and empty of people more times than not . . .

Our data did not support such criteria. While it was true that most strip plazas were little used, it did not follow that their shape was the reason. Some squarish plazas were little used too, and, conversely, several of the most heavily used spaces were in fact long, narrow

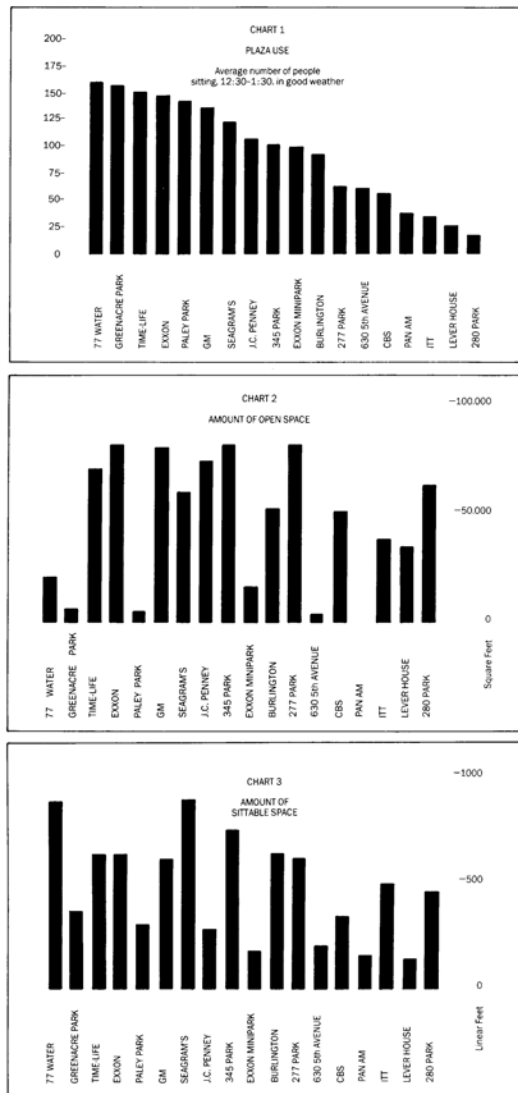


Figure 1

strips. One of the five most popular sitting places in New York is essentially an indentation in a building, long and narrow. Our research did not prove shape unimportant or designers' instincts misguided. As with the sun, however, it proved that other factors were more critical.

If not the shape of the space, what about the *amount* of it? Some conservationists believed this would be the key factor. In their view, people seek open space as a relief from overcrowding and it would follow that places with the greatest sense of space and light and air would draw the best. If we ranked plazas by the

amount of space they provided, there surely would be a positive correlation between space and people.

Once again we found no clear relationship. Several of the smallest spaces had the largest number of people, and several of the largest spaces had the least number of people . . .

What about the amount of *sittable* space? Here we began to get close. As we tallied the number of linear feet of sitting space, we could see that the plazas with the most tended to be among the most popular . . .

. . . No matter how many other variables we checked, one basic point kept coming through. We at last recognized that it was the major one.

People tend to sit most where there are places to sit.

This may not strike the reader as an intellectual bombshell, and now that I look back on our study I wonder why it was not more apparent to us from the beginning . . . Whatever the attractions of a space, it cannot induce people to come and sit if there is no place to sit.

INTEGRAL SEATING

The most basic kind of seating is the kind that is built into a place, such as steps and ledges. Half the battle is seeing to it that these features are usable by people. And there is a battle. Another force has been diligently at work finding ways to deny these spaces. Here are some of the ways:

Horizontal metal strip with sawtooth points.

Jagged rocks set in concrete (Southbridge House, New York City).

Spikes imbedded in ledges (Peachtree Plaza Hotel).

Railing placed to hit you in small of back (GM Plaza, New York City).

Canted ledges of slippery marble (Celanese Building, New York City).

It takes real work to create a lousy place. In addition to spikes and metal objects, there are steps to be made steep, additional surveillance cameras to be mounted, walls to be raised high. Just not doing such things can produce a lot of sitting space.

It won't be the most comfortable kind but it will have the great advantage of enlarging choice. The more sittable the inherent features are made, the more freedom people have to sit up front, in the back, to the side, in the sun, or out of it. This means designing

ledges and parapets and other flat surfaces so they can do double duty as seating, tables, and shelves. Since most building sites have some slope in them, there are bound to be opportunities for such features, and it is no more trouble to leave them sittable than not.

[...]

SITTING HEIGHT

One guideline we thought would be easy to establish was for sitting heights. It seemed obvious enough that somewhere around sixteen to seventeen inches would probably be the optimum. But how much higher or lower could a surface be and still be sittable? Thanks to slopes, several of the most popular ledges provided a range of continuously variable heights. The front ledge at Seagram, for example started at seven inches at one corner and rose to forty-four inches at the other. Here was an opportunity for a definitive study, we thought; by recording over time how many people sat at what heights, we would get a statistical measure of preferences.

We didn't . . . We had to conclude that people will sit almost anywhere between a height of one foot and three, and this was the range that was to be specified in the zoning. People will sit lower or higher, of course, but there are apt to be special conditions – a wall too high for most adults to mount but just right for teenagers.

A dimension that is truly important is the human backside. It is a dimension many architects ignore. Rarely will you find a ledge or bench that is deep enough to be sittable on both sides . . . Most frustrating are the ledges just deep enough to tempt people to sit on both sides, but too shallow to let them do so comfortably. At peak times people may sit on both sides but they won't be comfortable doing it. They will be sitting on the forward edge, awkwardly.

Thus to another of our startling findings: ledges and spaces two backsides deep seat more people than those that are not as deep . . .

[...]

Steps work for the same reason. They afford an infinity of possible groupings, and the excellent sight lines make all the seating great for watching the theatre of the street . . .

[...]

Circulation and sitting, in sum, are not antithetical but complementary. I stress this because a good many

planners think that the two should be kept separate. More to the point, so do some zoning codes. New York's called for "pedestrian circulation areas" separate from "activity areas" for sitting. People ignore such boundaries.

We felt that pedestrian circulation through and within plazas should be encouraged. Plazas that are sunken or elevated tend to attract low flows, and for that reason the zoning specifies that plazas be not more than three feet below street level or above it. The easier the flow between street and plaza the more likely they are to come in and tarry and sit.

This is true of the handicapped also. If a place is planned with their needs in mind, the place is apt to function more easily for everyone. Drinking fountains that are low enough for wheelchair users are low enough for children. Walkways that are made easier for the handicapped by ramps, handrails, and steps of gentle pitch are easier for all. The guidelines make such amenities mandatory . . . For the benefit of the handicapped, it is required that at least 5 percent of the seating spaces have backrests. These are not segregated for the handicapped. No facilities are segregated. The idea is to make all of the place useful for everyone.

BENCHES

Benches are design artifacts the purpose of which is to punctuate architectural photographs. They are most often sited in modular form, spaced equidistant from one another in a symmetry that is pleasing in plan view. They are not very good, however, for sitting. There are usually too few of them; they are too short and too narrow; they are isolated from other benches and from what action there is to look at.

[...]

Watch how benches fill up. The first arrival will usually take the end of a bench, not the middle. The next arrival will take the end of another bench. Subsequent arrivals head for whatever end spots are not taken. Only when there are few other places left will people sit in the middle of the bench, and some will elect to stand.

Since it's the ends of the benches that do most of the work, it could be argued that benches ought to be shortened so they're all end and no middle. But the unused middles are functional for not being used. They provide buffer space. They also provide choice,

and if it is the least popular choice, that does not negate its utility.

[...]

CHAIRS

We come now to a wonderful invention: the movable chair. Having a back, it is comfortable, and even more so if it has armrests as well. But the big asset is movability. Chairs enlarge choice: to move into the sun, out of it; to move closer to someone, further away from another.

The possibility of choice is as important as the exercise of it. If you know you can move if you want to, you can feel all the more comfortable staying put. This is why, perhaps, people so often approach a chair and then, before sitting on it, move the chair a few inches this way or that, finally ending up with the chair just about where it was in the first place. These moves are functional. They are a declaration of one's free will to oneself, and rather satisfying. In this one small matter you are the master of your fate.

Small moves can say things to other people. If a newcomer chooses a chair next to a couple in a crowded situation, he may make several moves with the chair. He is conveying a message: Sorry about the closeness, but it can't be helped and I am going to respect your privacy as you will mine. A reciprocal shift of a chair may signal acknowledgment.

Chair arranging by groups is a ritual worth watching. In a group of three or four women, one may be dominant and direct the sitting, including the fetching of an extra chair. More times, the members of the group work it out themselves, often with false starts and second choices. The chair arranging can take quite a bit of time on occasion – it is itself a form of recreation – but people enjoy it. Watching these exercises in civility is one of the pleasures of a good place.

Fixed individual seats deny choice. They may be good to look at, and in the form of stools, metal love seats, granite cubes, and the like, they make interesting decorative elements. That is their primary function. For sitting, however, they are inflexible and socially uncomfortable.

[...]

Where space is at a premium – in theatres, stadia – fixed seats are a necessity. In open spaces, however, they are uncalled for; there is so much space around them that the compression makes for awkward sitting

... On one campus a group of metal love seats was cemented to the paving with epoxy glue; in short order they were wrenched out of position by students. The designer is unrepentant. His love seats have won several design awards.

[...]

A salute to grass is in order. It is a wonderfully adaptable substance, and while it is not the most comfortable seating, it is fine for napping, sunbathing, picnicking, and Frisbee throwing. Like movable chairs, it also has the great advantage of offering people the widest possible choice of sitting arrangements. There are an infinity of possible groupings, but you will note that the most frequent has people self-positioned at oblique angles from each other.

Grass offers a psychological benefit as well. A patch of green is a refreshing counter to granite and concrete, and when people are asked what they would like to see in a park, trees and grass usually are at the top of the list ...

RELATIONSHIP TO THE STREET

Let us turn to a more difficult consideration. With the kind of amenities we have been discussing, there are second chances. If the designers have goofed on seating, more and better seating can be provided. If they have been too stingy with trees, more trees can be planted. If there is no food, a food cart can be put in – possibly a small pavilion or gazebo. If there is no water feature, a benefactor might be persuaded to donate a small pool or fountain. Thanks to such retrofitting, spaces regarded as hopeless dogs have been given new life.

What is most difficult to change, however, is what is most important: the location of the space and its relationship to the street. The real estate people are right about location, location, location. For a space to function truly well it must be central to the constituency it is to serve – and if not in physical distance, in visual accessibility ...

The street functions as part of the plaza or square; indeed, it is often hard to tell where the street leaves off and the plaza begins. The social life of the spaces flows back and forth between them. And the most vital space of all is often the street corner. Watch one long enough and you will see how important it is to the life of the large spaces. There will be people in 100 percent conversations or prolonged goodbyes. If there

is a food vendor at the corner, like Gus at Seagram, people will be clustered around him, and there will be a brisk traffic between corner and plaza.

It is a great show, and one of the best ways to make the most of it is, simply, not to wall off the plaza from it. Frederick Law Olmsted spoke of an "interior park" and an "outer park," and he argued that the latter – the surrounding streets – was vital to the enjoyment of the former. He thought it an abomination to separate the two with walls or, worse yet, with a spiked iron fence. "In expression and association," he said, "it is in the most distinct contradiction and discord with all the sentiment of a park. It belongs to a jail or to the residence of a despot who dreads assassination."

But walls are still being put up, usually in the mistaken notion that they will make the space feel safer. They do not . . . they make a space feel isolated and gloomy. Lesser defensive measures can work almost as much damage. The front rows of a space – whether ledges or steps or benches – are the best of sitting places, yet they are often modified against human use. At the General Motors Building on Fifth

Avenue, the front ledges face out on one of the greatest of promenades. But you cannot sit on the ledges for more than a minute or so. There is a fussy little railing that catches you right in the small of your back. I do not think it was deliberately planned to do so. But it does and you cannot sit for more than a few moments before your back hurts. Another two inches of clearance for the railing and you would be comfortable. But day after day, year after year, one of the great front rows goes scarcely used, for want of two inches. Canted ledges, especially ones of polished marble, are another nullifying feature. You can almost sit on them if you keep pressing down on your heel hard enough.

[...]

A good space beckons people in, and the progression from street to interior is critical in this respect. Ideally, the transition should be such that it's hard to tell where one ends and the other begins. You shouldn't have to make a considered decision to enter; it should be almost instinctive . . .

[...]